

recreated and paid homage to in the HBO series adaptation.

The in-game AI isn't the most clever or punishing we've faced in a post-apocalyptic survival horror game, but that's hardly the point of it all. Despite originally releasing at a time when the Walking Dead was super popular and gamers were already exposed to Resident Evil, The Last Of Us succeeded because it focused on just two characters – not overloading the senses by a whole ensemble cast, nor digressing into monsters and horror-based gore. The Last Of Us remains memorable even after a decade of its original PS3 release because it slowly makes you fall in love with its two protagonists.

Spoiler alert, and this is 100-percent true whichever way you look at it, but the game's just an excuse for players and audiences to lose themselves in Joel and Ellie's journey. It may mean different things to different people, for some it may look like just two people going on a dangerous adventure, while others may think it's a journey of self-discovery for both the protagonists of The Last Of Us. Just like in the game, the HBO series also gives you the same feeling, that you're holding hands with Joel and Ellie, continuing a shared journey without knowing how it would end. The drama and suspense feels raw, real almost; where circumstances seem less sugar coated and more believable to your pandemic-weary mind.

One of the things we felt very strongly after playing the original PS3 game was that if ever The Last Of Us was made into a TV series or movie,



then the character of Joel has to be played by Matthew Fox – guy who played Jack Shephard in LOST – because they look so spectacularly similar. However, Pedro Pascal quickly grows on you throughout the first episode, and by the second episode he is indistinguishable from Joel's rough appearance and gruff mannerisms in everything he does. The character of Ellie is faithfully reprised by Bella Ramsey, who looks and plays the part quite convincingly. Game of Thrones fans will obviously remember them from the hit HBO series, where both delivered memorable roles.

The tiny tinkering and tweaks done by the HBO showrunners to

the original game's storyline don't feel disrespectful, which is what's most surprising for all of us who've lost faith in adapted versions of anything these days. Everything from advancing a plot device to slowing it down, addressing holes in the original narrative to adding new layers that enhance the game's story, each of these embellishments show that the showrunners are fans just like the rest of us who played the game. Their creative liberties accentuate the story and make it even richer than we ever imagined.

The showrunners' fingerprints are immediately observed in scenes related to the original patient zero of the mycelium infection that starts affecting humans all over the world and some of the hive mind behaviour of the 'clickers', but no flight of fancy comes even close to the epic storyline the showrunners devised for the characters of Bill and

Frank, which make a brief appearance in episode two of the HBO series. Without spoiling the episode and saying too much, it makes you want to take a bow and celebrate the brilliant storytelling of the writers' room, especially.

Yes, we've only watched the first three episodes of the series, but we've seen enough to have no hesitation in saying that HBO's The Last Of Us is a wonderful adaptation of the decade-old game. Whether you've played the game or not, the story, and its characters played by two talented actors, is enough reason to tune into this unique saga on a weekly basis. *